Carlos César Chávez Padilla

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Development economist working on human capital and political economy, combining structural estimation with high-frequency data. Research Professional with James J. Heckman at the University of Chicago, and builder of Qhawarina, a real-time open-data platform for Peru.

Education

University of Chicago, Harris School of Public Policy 2024–2025
Master of Arts in Public Policy. *Merit Scholarship.*

Universidad Nacional Mayor de San Marcos (UNMSM) 2013–2017
B.A. in Economics. *Best Undergraduate Thesis.*

Universidad Nacional de Ingeniería 2018
Diplomas in Applied Econometrics and Finance.

Research Interests

Primary: Development Economics; Early Childhood Development. **Secondary:** Political Economy; Labor Economics.

Research Experience

Research Professional, Center for the Economics of Human Development, U. of Chicago 2025–present

- Work with Prof. James J. Heckman on early childhood skill formation and economic preferences.
- Research on how cognitive skills and personality traits relate to economic preferences in Chinese children, using structural modeling (CRRA and Expo-Power utilities).

Research Assistant, Harris School of Public Policy, U. of Chicago 2024–present

- With Prof. Christopher Blattman on gang recruitment in Colombia; with Prof. Martin Castillo-Quintana on game-theoretic models of extortion.

Pre-Doctoral Fellow, Georgetown University, McDonough School of Business 2023–2024

- With Prof. Amory Gethin on the political economy of social movements; built ML/NLP pipelines (DeBERTa transformers) on U.S. congressional records.

Research Analyst / Assistant, International Monetary Fund (MCM Department) 2020–2023

- Co-authored an IMF Working Paper on ethnic gaps and growth in Peru; research on political instability and macro outcomes across 180+ countries; supported country missions.

Earlier: Research Consultant, Inter-American Development Bank (2019–2020); Research Assistant, Universidad del Pacífico (2018–2019).

Selected Research

- **Relating Cognitive Skills and Personality Traits to Economic Preferences: Decision-Making under Cognitive Shocks and Guessing** (with S. Feng, J.J. Heckman, Z. Yang). *Accepted, Journal of Labor Economics.*
- **Did the Uruguay Round Spark Innovation? Evidence from Developing Countries Using Patent Data.** *Journal of Business.*
- **Auditing the Challenger: Legal Challenge Records as Adversarially Selected Forensic Samples.** *Under review, Election Law Journal.*

- **Cohort Effects of Democratization on Diffuse Regime Support and Emancipative Values.** *Under review, Political Behavior.*
- **What Reaches the Household: Tariff Pass-Through, Welfare and Calories in Peru, 2007–2012.** *Under review, World Development.*
- **When Firms Appear to Stop Innovating: Survey Seam Effects and the Measurement of Innovation Dynamics.** *Under review, Journal of Survey Statistics and Methodology.*
- **Missing Mass and Minimum Wages: Distributional Changes around Four Minimum Wage Increases in Peru.** *Under review, Journal of Development Studies.*
- **Do Coups Move Migration to the OECD? Bounds from a Staggered Design.** *Under review, Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies.*
- **The Macroeconomic Consequences of Political Instability.** *Under review, Journal of Economic Growth.*
- **How Economists Adopt Methods: Methodological Choice, Specialization, and Scientific Communities.** *Revise and resubmit, Journal of Economic Methodology.*
- **Terrorism and Regional Development: Evidence from Peru's Internal War.** *Revise and resubmit, World Development.*
- **The Anatomy of a Nobel Prize.** *Revise and resubmit, Empirical Economics.*

Other Working Papers

- **The Diffusion of Econometric Methods: A Structural Model of the Credibility Revolution.**
- **Automation Is Not a Sufficient Statistic: Robots, AI, and Inequality.**
- **Identifying Monetary Policy Shocks in an Administered-Rate Economy: Evidence from Peru.**
- **The Shining Path of Violence: Long-term Effects on Human Capital in Peru.**
- **Spatial Sorting and Conflict Migration.**

Publications

- Chávez, C. (2024). Minimum Wage and Ethnic Gaps: Who are the Winners? *Journal of Economics, Race, and Policy*, 7(2), 93–121.
- Chávez, C. (2023). The Effects of Mining Presence on Inequality, Labor Income, and Poverty: Evidence from Peru. *Mineral Economics*, 36(4), 615–642.
- Chávez, C. (2023). Domestic Violence, Labor Market, and Minimum Wage: Theory and Evidence. *Review of Economics*, 74(3), 195–233.
- Chávez, C. (2020). The Impact of the El Niño Phenomenon on Dry-Forest-Dependent Communities' Welfare in Northern Peru. *Ecological Economics.*
- Chávez, C. (2024). Estimating the Effects of Financial Liberalisation on Governability and Social Stability. *Foreign Trade Review*, 59(4), 588–614.
- Chávez, C. (2024). Latin American Firm Cooperation Payoff Evidence. *The International Trade Journal.*
- Chávez, C., Salinas, G., & Yuri, Z. (2022). Closing Peru's Ethnic Gaps Amidst Sustained Economic Growth. *IMF Working Paper* 2022/180.

Full list at Google Scholar.

Writing

Essays on economics and econometric methods at carloschavezp29.substack.com, including *On Causality*; *Why Macro Never Had a Credibility Revolution*; *Why Economists Linearize Everything*; *Why Christopher Sims Was So Great?*.

Honors, Conferences & Teaching

Honors: Merit Scholarship, U. of Chicago (2024); GSAS Future Leader Fellowship, Tufts (2023); Best Undergraduate Thesis, UNMSM (2017).

Conference presentations: NBER Summer Institute, Cambridge, MA (2026, with Feng, Heckman, Yang); Midwest Econometrics Group Meeting (2026, with Feng, Heckman, Yang); DePaul University, Chicago (2026, with Feng, Heckman, Yang); Jinan University, Guangzhou (2026, with Feng, Heckman, Yang); University College London (2026, with Feng, Heckman, Yang); Encuentro de Economistas, UNMSM, Lima (2026); IEA World Congress, Medellín (2023); LACEA–LAMES, Lima (2022); Bolivian Conference on Development Economics, La Paz (2022); Annual Conference of Peruvian Economists, Lima (2021–2022).

Teaching: Instructor, Universidad Nacional de Ingeniería — Econometric Theory, Econometrics I (2020–2022); TA, UNMSM — Microeconomics, Macroeconomics (2015–2018).

Skills & Affiliations

Programming: Stata, R (advanced); Python, Matlab (proficient). **Methods:** structural estimation, panel data econometrics, causal inference, instrumental variables, machine learning, NLP. **Languages:** Spanish (native), English (fluent). **Member:** AEA, Royal Economic Society, Econometric Society.

References

James J. Heckman — Henry Schultz Distinguished Service Professor, U. of Chicago, jjh@uchicago.edu.
Amory Gethin — Economist, Development Research Group, World Bank, agethin@worldbank.org.
Vincent Pons — Byron Wien Professor, Harvard Business School, vpons@hbs.edu.